

Hack That Mouse

...Did you even think you could?

Rossi Fernandes

Here at *Digit*, we take our games seriously. We play a lot of FPS games, especially on the LAN. However, a few of us also play online, and this is where things get complicated—it's a whole different ball game when we're on the Net, and we usually get fragged to kingdom come. It's not uncommon for us to hide in shameful misery, or just moan about our cheap mice, bad mouse pad, light-weight mouse, tangled wires... the list is never ending, as excuses generally are.

In this article we'll show you all the tips, tricks, and tweaks you may never even be aware of existed in your mouse. We'll warn you right here: performing some of the tweaks will void the warranty on your mouse, so be careful before removing any stickers—and perform the tweaks at your own risk.



Playing With Pads

While it is true that optical mice work well on almost any surface, the same can't be held true for laser mice. They tend to be picky when it comes to surfaces. Now, we know there are pads available like Icemat, Ratpad, Razer, Steelpad, Everglide, etc. However, they cost an arm and a leg, so most of us will never use them. We decided to look for cheaper alternatives.

The two main things we need are a hard base and the fabric that you want to put on it. We used acrylic as our hard base. If you want something cheaper, a thin sheet of wood, plastic, or aluminum works just as well. You might wonder if acrylic by itself would be a good surface. Its not! Optical mice fail miserably on acrylic just like on glass. We'll be talking of using glass itself as a mousepad a little later.

STEP 1 We went out and bought a 12 x 10-inch sheet of acrylic (Rs 50). We had a hacksaw and some sandpaper lying about, which we used to cut / shape the



Smoothing out the sharp edges

acrylic. We also got some fabric and a needle and thread.

STEP 2 We took the sheet of acrylic, created an outline of the shape we wanted, and then cut it.

STEP 3 We used sandpaper to smoothen out the cut edges.

STEP 4 Next, we held the fabric in place on the pad and made the necessary scissor markings.



Wrapping the fabric tightly around the board

STEP 5. We could either stick the cloth on the pad or hem up the pad. We kept things simple, but you can make a tight-fitting cover, or one that you can open easily and wash. Just make sure the surface is smooth, and has no wrinkles.



A complete mousepad @ Rs 50!

Some people would like to have a glass surface as their pad. This is easily done—just get a glass sheet cut to the size of your table or keyboard drawer, and have it etched. Optical and laser mice will not work unless you get the glass etched.



Using an etched sheet of glass as a mousepad



Wire Management

When gaming, mouse wires often get entangled and send your view in the game haywire. This is easily avoided by taking the

proper precaution when connecting all wires, and making sure the mouse wire is free to move.

If the cabinet is located beside the monitor, it's wise to run the wire from the opposite side of where all the other PC wires are. If the cabinet is located at the bottom, we often find ourselves tugging away at the mouse wire; after all, gravity will always pull it down. This means that there's never any slack in the wire, which is terrible when gaming, and quite irritating even with regular PC use. This is also easily solved by looping the wire around a paper-weight after getting the slack you need. For gaming however, it's probably a good idea to invest a little time and make a mouse-bungee.

Mouse-bungees basically avoid cables spilling over your table and keep the mouse wire suspended in the air for least resistance. Although products are sold for around Rs 600 to 700 that do exactly this, they're not widely available, and besides, why pay Rs 700 for something you can make yourself for one-fifth the price?

STEP 1 We needed a stand of some sort, and chose an old, broken microphone stand. You can use a bendable webcam stand, or one of those bendable table lamp stands. Plastic clips, rubber bands or a rubber/plastic sleeve is all we needed to hold the mouse cable in place.

STEP 2 We ran the mouse cable along the length of the stand. When you're doing this, remember to measure and leave enough space between the mouse and the stand, depending on placement.

STEP 3. We added clips wherever necessary, and tightened them to prevent the mouse wire from moving about.

STEP 4. Positioning is important. We positioned our mouse-bungee in such a way



Attaching clips to the stand

that there was little or no wire touching the table, and still had enough slack to move about easily. At home, you could add plastic hooks alongside your monitor or cabinet to hold the mouse cable in